Averse to Afghan groups with links to Islamabad, the partisans' logic of engagement, even with the post-2001 Afghan political dispensation, was rooted in containing Pakistan's influence. Clear about their aversion to the Afghan Taliban, the partisans were less clear on the extent to which India should support Karzai. Concerned that Islamabad would play favourites. Partisans wanted to cobble strong links with the former UF leadership and their contemporaries including the Massoud brothers, Abdullah, Mohaqiq, former Afghan intelligence chief Amrullah Saleh, Qanooni, and Dostum. If anything, they argued, just like during the 1990s, India should try to ameliorate differences between various former United Front leaders who had drifted apart after Massoud's assassination. Though open to the idea of engaging with Pashtun leaders, they did not want to make such engagement the cornerstone of India's Afghanistan policy. This had to do with both a generic lack of trust in Pashtun leaders among some Indian officials (as highlighted in chapter 4), and Pakistan's influence in south and east Afghanistan. Implementing such partisanship in practice, however, was impossible due to international pressure. The only time when partisan advocacy gained potency was during crises like attacks on Indian citizens and assets in Afghanistan, and briefly after the 2010 London conference where reconciliation with the Taliban was internationally institutionalised.

Katju, X, and R, another senior R&AW officer, were among some officials who advocated anti-Karzai partisanship. Influential in India's strategic and foreign policy circles, despite having retired, Katju did not mince words when expressing his reservations about Karzai's capability to handle the Afghan Taliban's resurgence:

> In the 1990s, the Taliban and Pakistan could not fully achieve their objectives largely because of Ahmed Shah Massoud. Mr. Karzai is no Massoud but he can meet the current challenge even now if he abandons the narrow politics he has pursued since 2001. More than ever, he needs the skills of the Panjsheri leaders, Abdullah and Qanooni, the analytical capacities of the former Intelligence Chief, Amrullah Saleh, the courage of the Hazara leader, Mohaqiq, and the tenacity of the Uzbek leader, Dostum. Along with them he needs to travel, with all its risks, especially to Pashtun areas to warn against the long-term dangers the Taliban represent to Afghanistan's future. Perhaps this is too much to ask of Mr. Karzai.[108]

R categorically added that immediately after the Bonn conference, and before Karzai's political sustainability was assured in the 2004 elections, 'we [India] had